

Gentle Parenting Tantrum Toolkit

20 Calm-Down Cards + Scripts + Meltdown Tracker

PRINTABLE TOOLKIT

Instant Download | Print at Home | 8.5 x 11

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Bible Made Simple Publishing

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DISCLAIMER:

This is an educational resource, not professional advice.

Consult a licensed professional for specific concerns.

If this helped your family, please leave a 5-star review!

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How to Use This Toolkit

PRINTING:

- Print on standard 8.5 x 11 paper
- Cardstock recommended for charts and cards
- Laminate frequently-used pages for durability
- Color printing recommended (works in B&W too)

GETTING STARTED:

1. Read through the entire toolkit first
2. Choose 1-2 tools to implement THIS WEEK
3. Post visual tools where your family will see them
4. Revisit and rotate tools as needs change
5. Share with co-parent/caregiver for consistency

TIPS FOR SUCCESS:

- Involve your child in setting up the system
- Be consistent for at least 2 weeks before adjusting
- Celebrate small wins ? progress over perfection
- Take photos of your setup and share your wins!

Gentle Parenting Tantrum Toolkit

20 Calm-Down Cards + Scripts + Trackers

CALM DOWN STRATEGIES FOR KIDS

1. Take 5 deep belly breaths
2. Squeeze a stress ball tight then release
3. Hug yourself and count to 10
4. Go to your calm corner
5. Stomp your feet 10 times
6. Blow out birthday candles (exhale slow)
7. Name 5 things you can see
8. Drink cold water slowly
9. Draw how you feel
10. Ask for a hug

CALM-DOWN CARD #1

When your child is: HITTING

Situation: Hitting

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about hitting."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #2

When your child is: SCREAMING

Situation: Screaming

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about screaming."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #3

When your child is: THROWING THINGS

Situation: Throwing Things

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about throwing things."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #4

When your child is: NOT SHARING

Situation: Not Sharing

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about not sharing."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #5

When your child is: BEDTIME REFUSAL

Situation: Bedtime Refusal

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about bedtime refusal."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #6

When your child is: FOOD REFUSAL

Situation: Food Refusal

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about food refusal."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #7

When your child is: LEAVING THE PARK

Situation: Leaving The Park

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about leaving the park."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #8

When your child is: GETTING DRESSED

Situation: Getting Dressed

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about getting dressed."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #9

When your child is: IN THE CAR SEAT

Situation: In The Car Seat

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about in the car seat."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #10

When your child is: PUBLIC MELTDOWN

Situation: Public Meltdown

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about public meltdown."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #11

When your child is: WANTING A TOY

Situation: Wanting A Toy

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about wanting a toy."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #12

When your child is: LOSING A GAME

Situation: Losing A Game

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about losing a game."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #13

When your child is: SIBLING CONFLICT

Situation: Sibling Conflict

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about sibling conflict."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #14

When your child is: WAKING UP GRUMPY

Situation: Waking Up Grumpy

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about waking up grumpy."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #15

When your child is: BATH TIME BATTLE

Situation: Bath Time Battle

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about bath time battle."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #16

When your child is: HOMEWORK FRUSTRATION

Situation: Homework Frustration

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about homework frustration."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #17

When your child is: TRANSITION TANTRUM

Situation: Transition Tantrum

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about transition tantrum."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #18

When your child is: OVERTIRED MELTDOWN

Situation: Overtired Meltdown

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about overtired meltdown."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #19

When your child is: HUNGER TANTRUM

Situation: Hunger Tantrum

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about hunger tantrum."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

CALM-DOWN CARD #20

When your child is: SEPARATION ANXIETY

Situation: Separation Anxiety

STEP 1 - Get on their level:

"I see you are really upset about separation anxiety."

STEP 2 - Validate the emotion:

"It is okay to feel frustrated/angry/sad."

STEP 3 - Set the limit:

"AND we cannot hit/throw/scream."

STEP 4 - Offer alternatives:

"You CAN stomp your feet / squeeze this / use words."

STEP 5 - Stay close:

"I am here when you are ready for a hug."

MELTDOWN TRACKING LOG

Use this to identify tantrum patterns and triggers

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____ AM/PM

What happened BEFORE the meltdown?

What was the tantrum behavior?

How long did it last? ____ minutes

What helped them calm down?

Possible trigger (circle): Hungry / Tired / Overstimulated / Transition / Told No / Other

What I will try differently next time:

Meltdown Log #1

Entry #1

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #2

Entry #2

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #3

Entry #3

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #4

Entry #4

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #5

Entry #5

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #6

Entry #6

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #7

Entry #7

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #8

Entry #8

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #9

Entry #9

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

Meltdown Log #10

Entry #10

Date: ____/____/____ Time: ____

Trigger:

Behavior:

Duration: ____ min

What worked:

Pattern I notice:

WHAT TO SAY INSTEAD OF NO

1. Instead of NO: Try "Yes, after you..."
2. Instead of STOP: Try "Let's try this instead..."
3. Instead of BAD BOY/GIRL: Try "That choice was not safe"
4. Instead of BECAUSE I SAID SO: Try "The reason is..."
5. Instead of CALM DOWN: Try "I see big feelings. I am here."
6. Instead of YOU ALWAYS: Try "I noticed today that..."
7. Instead of WAIT TILL DAD GETS HOME: Try "Let's solve this now"
8. Instead of FINE DO WHATEVER: Try "The answer is still no AND I love you"
9. Instead of WHAT IS WRONG WITH YOU: Try "What's going on for you?"
10. Instead of STOP CRYING: Try "It is okay to cry. I am here."

PARENT PAUSE CARD

When YOU are about to lose your cool:

STOP. Before you react:

- ☐ Am I hungry, tired, or stressed?
- ☐ Is this behavior age-appropriate?
- ☐ Will my reaction help or escalate?
- ☐ What does my child NEED right now?
- ☐ Can this wait 5 minutes?

Take 3 deep breaths.

Lower your voice to a whisper.

Get on their level physically.

Remember: They are not giving you a hard time.

They ARE having a hard time.

You Got This!

Parenting is hard. You are doing amazing.

Leave a 5-star review if this helped your family!

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